roam the countryside, making them difficult for enemies to target and destroy, unlike fixed missile silos. Yet the very nature of such a decentralized force also means a localized response to any problems.

Though some of North Korea's missiles are apparently solid-fueled, most use less stable liquid fuel with an engine designed during the Soviet era. Even the comparatively more stable liquid propellants used today are among the most toxic substances on earth, and transfer accidents have been a hazard of the job.[6] In August 1978, in one of the worst instances, a fuel line failed during a propellant transfer at a Titan II missile silo at McConnell Air Force Base in Kansas, releasing over thirteen thousand gallons of rocket fuel (dinitrogen tetroxide) and sending a "thundercloud" of orange vapor spewing out of the silo, killing one airman.[7] If North Korea has had similar accidents, we don't yet know, but in the worst-case scenario a fuel accident could cause the explosion of a missile, as in the 1980 Damascus incident. It is unlikely but conceivable that a warhead jettisoned from a missile that explodes due to a fueling mistake could detonate. A nuclear detonation on North Korean soil would be hard to cover up, and Kim Jong-un would undoubtedly deflect blame by accusing the Americans, South Koreans, or Japanese of sabotage or an attack, sparking a military crisis that could be uncontrollable.

Similarly, only on-site North Korean nuclear launch teams would be available to correct an electrical glitch that starts a firing sequence for a loaded missile or to repair a faulty missile or one that has been damaged in some other way while being transported. We don't know if North Korea will have nuclear crisis teams, but even if they do, such expertise may not reach a mobile launcher with a problem in time. In the 1980 Damascus accident, it took the US Air Force hours to dispatch the right teams to the remote silo, by which time it was too late to prevent the missile from exploding. And those were some of America's most highly trained disaster response teams.

We have no idea if Pyongyang is even planning on developing a similar crisis response infrastructure throughout its nuclear enterprise, since to do so would be to call into question the reliability of Kim's